

FRONTEX

EUROPEAN BORDER AND COAST GUARD AGENCY

A Strengthened European Border and Coast Guard

Built on Trust to Protect and Connect Europe

Technical and Operational Strategy
for European Integrated Border Management
2023-2027



FRONTEX

EUROPEAN BORDER AND COAST GUARD AGENCY

A Strengthened European Border and Coast Guard

Built on Trust to Protect and Connect Europe

Technical and Operational Strategy
for European Integrated Border Management
2023-2027

Table of Contents

Foreword 5

The Road to Pamplona and Beyond 6

1. Introduction 9

1.1. Setting the Strategic Technical and Operational Ambition 10

1.2. How to Read this Strategy 12

2. Setting the Scene 15

2.1. Context 16

2.1.1. Legal Basis for European Integrated Border Management and Integrated Planning 16

2.1.2. The Future in a Time of Uncertainty 18

2.1.3. Multiannual Strategic Policy Goals, Key European Integrated Border Management Principles and Strategic Guidelines 20

2.1.4. Schengen 2019-2020 Thematic Evaluation 21

2.2. Concept — Adding European Value in Support of Security and Prosperity across Relevant Policies of the European Union 22

3. Strategy 27

3.1. Vision 2027 — A Strengthened European Border and Coast Guard Built on Trust to Protect and Connect Europe 28

3.2. Goals and Success Measures 30

3.3. The Process of Achieving the Goals 37

3.3.1. The Integrated Process for Planning and Implementation 37

3.3.2. Process Steps 38

3.3.3. Actions 43

3.3.4. Interlinkages between Goals, Process Steps and Actions 43

4. Implementation of the Strategy 47

4.1. European Level 48

4.2. National Level 48

4.3. Monitoring 51

5. Evaluation 53

Annex 55

Foreword

This document outlines the second Technical and Operational Strategy for European Integrated Border Management, marking a significant step forward since the initial Strategy introduced by the Agency's Management Board in March 2019. With the enhanced mandate of the European Border and Coast Guard, implemented ten months later, and the creation of the Standing Corps — the first uniformed law enforcement service at the EU level — we have seen a boost in operational effectiveness and the ability to respond swiftly across operational areas. In the four years since, amidst a global health crisis and escalating conflicts in our vicinity that have led to unprecedented migratory pressures, the Standing Corps has demonstrated its indispensable role in these increasingly complex times.

The development of this Strategy stems from the innovations introduced in the 2019 mandate, aligning with the Multiannual Strategic Policy Cycle for European Integrated Border Management. This policy cycle integrates strategic guidance from policymakers with actionable operational steps, return measures, and future investments. Crafted through a collaborative effort between the Agency, Member States, and



with robust support from the European Commission, this Strategy is a response to the Multiannual Strategic Policy set by the European Commission in March 2023. It outlines our collective vision for the next five years, detailing the steps to achieve our objectives, highlighting indicators of success, and presenting a detailed action plan. Member States will align their national European Integrated Border Management strategies with this comprehensive approach, ensuring a unified progression towards our 2027 goals. This will pave the way for the next phase of the Multiannual Strategic Policy Cycle for European Integrated Border Management.

Hans Leijtens
Executive Director

The Road to Pamplona and Beyond

The journey towards the adoption of this Technical and Operational Strategy started as early as March 2019, following the adoption of its predecessor, which was finalised in in the midst of the negotiations of the second European Border and Coast Guard Regulation.[1] The step-change for border management and returns was just months away and the implementation of the first Technical and Operational Strategy would subsequently be overtaken by working within the extensive mandate of the new Regulation. With strict deadlines set in the Regulation, much of our collaborative focus towards 2021 was given to the establishment and deployment of the first ever uniformed service of the Union — the European Border and Coast Guard Standing Corps. As the most tangible and visible change stemming from the Regulation, the growing Standing Corps (to which both Member States and the Agency contribute) has proved its worth ever since, providing a common operationally available capability, able to respond to the increasingly volatile situation at the external borders.

In 2022, our focus shifted towards delivering what you see in this publication. Hot on the heels of the Commission's proposal for a Multiannual Strategic Policy tabled in May 2022, the then recently formalised Management Board Working Group for European Integrated Border Management became the place for taking the necessary steps to find common ground on where we, as a community, envisage European Integrated Border Management to be in 2027. Spearheaded by a drafting team, things began to take real shape just after the adoption of the Multiannual Strategic Policy for European Integrated Border Management in March 2023. The drafting team met regularly over the course of the months that followed to review the



Signe Højland Jensen (Denmark)
Drafting Team Member and Co-Spokesperson for the Management Board Working Group on European Integrated Border Management

Aija Kalnaja (Frontex)
Co-Spokesperson for the Management Board Working Group on European Integrated Border Management

1 Regulation (EU) 2019/1896 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 13 November 2019 on the European Border and Coast Guard and repealing Regulations (EU) No 1052/2013 and (EU) 2016/1624.

Agency's progress on developing a Technical and Operational Strategy, providing advice and helping navigate the way to achieving a version that all members of the Management Board Working Group could agree on.

In September 2023, in a sunny Pamplona in Spain, the venue for the 96th Management Board meeting, hosted by the Spanish Presidency, we reached our destination. Our common Technical and Operational Strategy — one size that fits all — was adopted and will steer us all the way to 2027, when a new Policy Cycle is slated to commence. National European Integrated Border Management strategies are in the process of being aligned and in the works is also a governance mechanism to help us measure our collective progress.

As Co-Spokespersons for the Management Board Working Group on European Integrated Border Management, our shared responsibility also includes acknowledging the contributions of the Working Group members, as well as the contributions of all the experts in the many national authorities, Frontex, the Commission and other EU Agencies, namely the European Union Agency for Asylum (EUAA), European Union Agency for Law Enforcement Cooperation (EUROPOL), European Fisheries Control Agency (EFCA), European Maritime Safety Agency (EMSA), European Union Agency for the Operational Management of Large-Scale IT Systems in the Area of Freedom, Security and Justice (eu-LISA) and European Union Agency for Fundamental Rights (FRA).

A special thanks goes to those at the core of the strategy development process.

Frontex

Dinesh Rempling
Co-Author and Vice Co-Spokesperson for the Management Board Working Group on European Integrated Border Management

Urszula Kubka-Grenda
Project Manager and Co-Author

Alexandros Lefteratos
Project Support and Content Contributor

Monica Gariup
Drafting Team Member

Richard Ares Baumgartner
Drafting Team Member

European Commission

Ilker Aydin, *Drafting Team Member*
Jesse Seppälä, *Drafting Team Member*

Member States

Wietse Jelles *(Netherlands)*
Drafting Team Member and Vice Co-Spokesperson for the Management Board Working Group on European Integrated Border Management

Johann Riedl-Scharl *(Austria)*
Drafting Team Member

Marko Saareks *(Finland)*
Drafting Team Member

Helen Neider-Veerme *(Estonia)*
Drafting Team Member

Cristina Jianu *(Romania)*
Drafting Team Member

Emil Ochea *(Romania)*
Drafting Team Member

Let our shared journey continue!



Introduction

1

1.1. Setting the Strategic Technical and Operational Ambition

In line with the European Border and Coast Guard Regulation (the 'Regulation'), **the purpose of the Technical and Operational Strategy for European Integrated Border Management is to translate political goals and policy steer into a strategic European framework for the implementation of the Multiannual Strategic Policy for European Integrated Border Management**[2] through concrete technical and operational actions carried out by the European Border and Coast Guard. As such, it interlinks the European and national levels, outlining what is of common interest to the European Border and Coast Guard and where the respective national European Integrated Border Management strategies should be aligned accordingly.

This is the **second strategy for the European Integrated Border Management**. The first was adopted by the Management Board of Frontex - the European Border and Coast Guard Agency in March 2019[3] under the previous European Border and Coast Guard Regulation.[4] It consolidated the concept for European Integrated Border Management and integrated several principles and objectives included in the Council Conclusions on European Integrated Border Management[5] and relevant Commission communications.[6] It was established in the midst of a turbulent point in history, when the campaigns of the Islamic State were still ongoing, not least impacting the European area as it continued to deal with the emergent migration crisis of 2015. It was a time when the world was coming to terms with Brexit as well as a clear shift in the US foreign policy, all while Russia continued its systematic efforts to strengthen its position on the global scene through incremental escalation of aggression over the last two decades.

2 Multiannual Strategic Policy Cycle as referred to in Article 8 Regulation (EU) 2019/1896 on the European Border and Coast Guard.
3 Management Board Decision 2/2019 adopting a Technical and Operational Strategy for European Integrated Border Management.
4 Regulation (EU) 2016/1624 on the European Border and Coast Guard.
5 European Council meeting (28 June 2018) – Conclusions, EUCO 9/18.
6 Annex to the Progress Report on the European Agenda on Migration, COM(2018)250 final, Brussels 14.3.2018.

Since 2019 the external borders of the EU have faced numerous challenges, not least for European and national authorities dealing with the management of external borders and implementing returns. Hence, this strategy has been designed to take yet another step forward. By implementing the Commission Communication establishing the Multiannual Strategic Policy for European Integrated Border Management,[7] it is raising the ambition of the European Border and Coast Guard, and outlining where European Integrated Border Management is expected to be by the end of 2027, when this Multiannual Strategic Policy Cycle, started in 2023, will be concluded. The overall aim is to pave the way towards further integrating the European Border and Coast Guard in order to implement European Integrated Border Management as a shared responsibility of Frontex and the relevant national authorities[8] of Member States[9] and the Agency. **The vision for 2027 is a strengthened European Border and Coast Guard, built on trust, that will protect and connect Europe** and, thereby, **help increase its effectiveness** in managing the borders, working together within and at the external borders as well as with and within Third Countries while implementing returns in an integrated and efficient way, **fully compliant with international and European law, in full respect for fundamental rights.**

7 Communication from the Commission to the European Parliament and the Council Establishing the Multiannual Strategic Policy for European Integrated Border Management, Strasbourg, 14.3.2023, COM(2023) 146 final.

8 National authorities responsible for border management, including coast guards to the extent that they carry out border control tasks, and the national authorities responsible for return.

9 European Union Member States and Schengen Associated Countries.

1.2. How to Read this Strategy

This document is composed of two parts. The first part is the actual Strategy. It sets the scene by presenting the legal framework, describing future risks and opportunities, and providing an overview of the Commission Communication establishing the Multiannual Strategic Policy for European Integrated Border Management and its links to other relevant policy areas. It further defines eight goals, the majority of which originate from the Multiannual Strategic Policy. Each goal is linked to a success measure, allowing implementation to be monitored and assessed. For each goal, a set of actions have been identified to implement the respective steps in the Integrated Planning and Implementation Process for European Integrated Border Management. The details of the Actions can be found in the Implementation Plan, the second part and the Annex to the Strategy. It is aligned with the requirements stated in the Communication establishing the Multiannual Strategic Policy.

Pursuant to Article 8(6) of the Regulation, Member States shall establish national strategies for European Integrated Border Management in line with Multiannual Strategic Policy and the technical and operational strategy, aligned with the Union requirements. The specific situations of Member States, in particular their geographical locations, may entail that the national strategies need to focus more on certain goals of this Strategy.

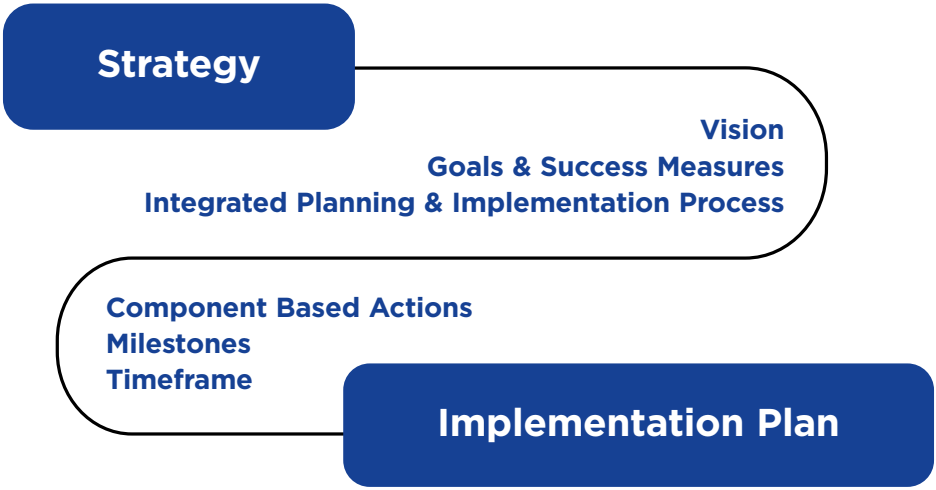


Figure 1: An overview of the core elements in the Strategy and its Implementation Plan



Setting the Scene

2

2.1. Context

2.1.1. Legal Basis for European Integrated Border Management and Integrated Planning

The Regulation defines **European Integrated Border Management as the core business of the European Border and Coast Guard**, stating that the objective of Union policy in the field of external border management is to develop and implement European Integrated Border Management at a national[10] and Union level, as a necessary consequence of the free movement of persons within the Union and a fundamental component of an area of freedom, security, and justice.[11] European Integrated Border Management is central to improving migration management. The aim is to handle the crossing of the external borders by bona fide travellers efficiently, to address both migratory challenges and potential future threats, to contribut to combatting crime with a cross-border dimension and an increased level of internal security within the Union as well as to implement returns. At all times, it is necessary to act in a manner that safeguards the free movement of persons within the Union[12] and in full respect of EU and international law, including fundamental rights as enshrined in the Charter of Fundamental Rights of the European Union[13] and relevant international law, notably the right to international protection of persons on the move and the principle of non-refoulement.

The Regulation further describes European Integrated Border Management as a set of **fifteen components**[14] and explains the concept of the **four-tier access control model.**

10 Treaty on the European Union Article 4(3): Pursuant to the principle of sincere cooperation, the Union and the Member States shall, in full mutual respect, assist each other in carrying out tasks which flow from the Treaties. The Member States shall take any appropriate measure, general or particular, to ensure fulfilment of the obligations arising out of the Treaties or resulting from the acts of the institutions of the Union. The Member States shall facilitate the achievement of the Union's tasks and refrain from any measure which could jeopardise the attainment of the Union's objectives.
Treaty on the Functioning of the European Union Article 291.1: Member States shall adopt all measures of national law necessary to implement legally binding Union acts.

11 Recital 1 of Regulation (EU) 2019/1896.

12 Ibid.

13 Charter of Fundamental Rights of the European Union." Official Journal of the European Union C83, vol. 53, European Union, 2010.

14 Article 3 of Regulation (EU) 2019/1896: a) Border Control; b) Search and Rescue; c) Risk Analysis; d) Information Exchange and Cooperation between Member States; e) Inter-Agency Cooperation among National authorities; f) Cooperation Among Union Institutions, Bodies and Agencies; g) Cooperation with Third Countries; h) Technical and Operational Measures within the Schengen Area; i) Return of Third Country Nationals; j) Use of State-of-the-Art Technologies including large-scale information systems; k) Quality Control Mechanisms including Schengen Evaluation, Vulnerability Assessment and National mechanisms; l) Solidarity Mechanisms including Union Funding; m) Fundamental Rights; n) Education and Training; o) Research and Innovation.

Moreover, the Regulation establishes a Multiannual Strategic Policy Cycle which, based on the Strategic Risk Analysis[15] developed by the Agency, starts with the adoption of a Communication by the European Commission following discussions in the European Parliament and Council. The Regulation states that the Multiannual Strategic Policy Cycle "should set out an integrated, unified and continuous process for providing strategic guidelines to all the relevant actors at the Union level and at the national level in the area of border management and return so that those actors are able to implement European integrated border management in a coherent manner."[16] The Multiannual Strategic Policy Cycle spans a period of five years but can be relaunched at any time if deemed necessary. Based on a proposal by the Frontex Executive Director, the Management Board should adopt a technical and operational strategy for European integrated border management within six months of the adoption of the European Integrated Border Management Communication. The Technical and Operational Strategy shall be in line with the Multiannual Strategic Policy and structured around the fifteen components outlined in Article 3 of Regulation. Subsequently, the Member States shall establish national strategies in line with the Multiannual Strategic Policy and and the technical and operational strategy, in close cooperation between all national authorities responsible for the management of external borders and return. Four years after the adoption of the Multiannual Strategic Policy, the Commission shall carry out a thorough evaluation of its implementation.[17]

Lastly, the Regulation states that European Integrated Border Management should be implemented through integrated planning between Member States and the Agency, which comprises operational planning, contingency planning and capability development planning.[18]

On 14 March 2023, the Commission adopted the Communication establishing the Multiannual Strategic Policy for European Integrated Border Management, which builds on the discussion that took place in the European Parliament and Council on the Commission policy document, proposed in May 2022, developing a Multiannual Strategic Policy for European Integrated Border Management. With the adoption of the Commission Communication, the five-year Multiannual Strategic Policy Cycle was established for the period 2023 to 2027.

15 Article 8(4) of Regulation (EU) 2019/1896: On the basis of the strategic risk analysis for European Integrated Border Management referred to in Article 29(2), the Commission shall prepare a policy document developing a Multiannual Strategic Policy for European Integrated Border Management. The Commission shall submit that policy document to the European Parliament and to the Council for discussion. Following that discussion, the Commission shall adopt a communication establishing the multiannual strategic policy for European Integrated Border Management.
16 Recital 16 of Regulation (EU) 2019/1896.
17 Ibid.
18 Article 9 of Regulation (EU) 2019/1896.

In the Conclusions[19] adopted on 9 February 2023, the European Council called on the Council and the Commission, with the support of relevant EU agencies, to develop a common situational awareness, to improve monitoring of data on migratory flows both into and within the EU, to detect new migratory trends more quickly. The European Border and Coast Guard has a role to contribute to this policy objective.

2.1.2. The Future in a Time of Uncertainty

The Frontex Strategic Risk Analysis 2022[20] highlights the trend towards an increasingly hostile multipolar world, fuelled, among others, by the ongoing war in Ukraine caused by Russia's aggression. With armed conflicts likely to recur, alongside crises induced by climate change such as famines, floods, heatwaves and droughts, the EU's external borders will continue to be faced with high migratory pressure. From February 2022 to mid-2023, about four million registrations for temporary protection of persons fleeing Ukraine have been made in the EU. This observed step-change in migration flows will continue along with other substantial migration flows, most likely originating from Southeast Asia, Africa and the Middle East.

Hybrid threats[21] will continue to evolve. Exploited by both state and non-state actors, these threats will be used increasingly where international tensions reach beyond what is peaceful yet falling short of what is a fully fledged war, aiming to destabilise the EU and weaken its stance in the international community. Instrumentalisation of values, migration and information as well as the supply of e.g. food, energy, raw materials, technological components and know-how will strengthen the need for strategic autonomy, which in turn will constrain the existing global supply chains that over decades have achieved economies of scale. This will affect both the availability and lifecycle costs of border management and return capabilities.

Networks with the aim of profiting from illegal activities will always have an interest in the external borders. Terrorism will seek to cause havoc within or outside the European area, radicalising societies in support of their causes. Those seeking financial gains will e.g. continue to smuggle contraband, drugs and munitions,

19 Communication from the Commission to the European Parliament and the Council Establishing the Multiannual Strategic Policy for European Integrated Border Management, Strasbourg, 14.3.2023, COM(2023) 146 final.

20 Strategic Risk Analysis 2022; Frontex Reference Number SAMD/RAU/SFALEM/7782/2022; FPI 22.5042; Paper version: TT-09-22-275-EN-C ISBN 978-92-9467-430-2 doi: 10.2819/618977; PDF version: TT-09-22-275-EN-N ISBN 978-92-9467-431-9 doi: 10.2819/76165.

21 Hybrid threats refer to when state or non-state actors seek to exploit the vulnerabilities of the EU to their own advantage by using in a coordinated way a mixture of measures (i.e. diplomatic, military, economic, technological) while remaining below the threshold of formal warfare. Source: https://defence-industry-space.ec.europa.eu/eu-defence-industry/hybrid-threats_en.

as well as trafficking human beings into the European area, while engaging in transporting European waste to other parts of the world. The methods will become more sophisticated, hidden under the cover of legal business structures, facilitated by white-collar- and cyber-crime, the growth in international trade and the security weaknesses of global supply chains and their logistics systems. The expanding shipping industry and seaports will be exploited to facilitate all types of illicit trade.

With the world growing increasingly digitalised and connected, border control processes will become more automated, to cope with increasing passenger flows and the need for more secure borders, for example. Enabled by the rollout of the large-scale IT systems, this will both make legitimate trade and travel easier and reinforce the internal security of the Union. The increased digitalisation of borders and travel and trade continuums will, however, leave them more susceptible to cyber threats from those wanting to either disrupt control of the external borders or deceive authorities.

As advances in technology will further proliferate, making everyday life easier through increased automation and connectivity, non-state actors will also seek to benefit from the race for technological superiority between state actors. Capabilities and inherent technologies for border management, defence, security and space are converging. All stakeholders will benefit from developments in e.g. artificial intelligence, computing, unmanned systems, materials, three-dimensional printing and energy efficiency. Technologies will further help reduce hazardous environmental impacts, while advances in geo-engineering will support more wide-spread and effective climate change mitigation measures by attempting to control weather conditions. They will, however, require robust governance to avoid unwanted consequences, especially if these technologies end up in the wrong hands. Reliance on space will also continue for surveillance and communication capabilities and there will be a need to protect these vested EU interests.

Diseases represent another tangible threat. The COVID-19 pandemic demonstrated that they are not tied to borders. They transmit across the globe via humans, animals and the environment.

The above-mentioned developments and trends are major factors contributing to the challenges currently faced by the Schengen area. Partly due to the pressure on the external borders, security risks, unauthorized migration flows within Schengen area and inefficient implementation of return policies, the Schengen area is encountering significant issues, which has also led to some Member States temporarily reintroducing internal border controls. Measures in the context of the Multiannual Strategic Policy should thus contribute to restoring the proper functioning of the Schengen area.

In these uncertain times of fast-changing challenges in border management, it is crucial to reinforce and build upon a European whole-of-government approach to border management that remains firmly rooted in respect for EU and international law, including fundamental rights.

2.1.3. Multiannual Strategic Policy Goals, Key European Integrated Border Management Principles and Strategic Guidelines

The Multiannual Strategic Policy provides the high-level steer for European Integrated Border Management over the next five years for both national authorities and Frontex. The Policy states that European Integrated Border Management pursues different multiannual strategic policy goals in parallel:

- To **facilitate legitimate border crossings**
- To **increase the efficiency of the Union's return Policy**
- To ensure the **effective prevention of unauthorised crossings** of the external borders
- To **prevent and detect serious crime with a cross-border dimension**, such as migrant smuggling, terrorism, trafficking in human beings, arms trafficking and drugs trafficking
- To achieve **effective cooperation with Third Countries**
- To ensure the **swift registration and provision of care to persons in need** of, or applying for, international protection as well as other vulnerable persons crossing EU borders.

According to the Commission Communication, these Multiannual Strategic Policy goals are reflected in a number of key European Integrated Border Management principles[22] which stem directly from the Regulation. They support the Policy guidelines and strategic priorities for European Integrated Border Management which are defined in relation to the fifteen European Integrated Border Management components set out in Article 3 of the Regulation and outlined in Annex I of the Commission Communication.

22 The shared responsibility and duty to cooperate in good faith and exchange information; European Integrated Border Management should be based on the Four-Tier Access Control Model; The indispensability of comprehensive and near-to-real-time situational awareness; The constant readiness to respond to emerging threats, which require an inter-agency approach through well-established coordination, communication and integrated planning system between the Agency and Member States.

2.1.4. Schengen 2019-2020 Thematic Evaluation

One of the requirements for implementation of the Multiannual Strategic Policy is that it should be compliant with the Council Conclusions of 2020[23] drawn upon the findings and recommendations issued in the Schengen 2019-2020 thematic evaluation of the national European Integrated Border Management strategies.[24]

Therefore, the Strategy has been designed considering the need for the following elements to be successfully addressed in the national strategies:

- **Aligning with the policy priorities** set by the EU regarding European Integrated Border Management
- **Enhancing collaboration and cooperation** among different national agencies involved in border management to ensure a coordinated approach
- **Establishing clear priorities** for actions and allocating resources effectively to address key challenges and objectives
- **Creating a national governance mechanism** that includes a central coordination authority to streamline decision-making and coordination processes
- **Ensuring effective management of human resources** involved in border management, including providing appropriate training capacities
- **Appropriately allocating funding** from both national and European sources to support the implementation of the strategy
- **Developing a robust system to monitor progress**, evaluate outcomes, and ensure effective implementation of the strategy
- **Regularly reviewing and updating the strategy** to incorporate changes, adapt to evolving circumstances and improve its effectiveness

Encompassing these elements will contribute to fostering a cohesive and effective approach to European Integrated Border Management across all Member States.

23 Council Implementing Decision 14220/20 (LIMITED).

24 The Schengen Evaluation and Monitoring Mechanism (SEMM) monitors the implementation of the Schengen acquis (common set of Schengen rules that apply to all Member States) and recommends improvements. The purpose of the mechanism is to ensure an effective, consistent, timely and transparent application of Schengen rules by Schengen member states, while at the same time maintaining a high level of mutual trust between them.

2.2. Concept – Adding European Value in Support of Security and Prosperity across Relevant Policies of the European Union

At the nexus of internal and external policies, the integrated management of external borders should add value to the security of the European area of free movement, while facilitating interaction with partners outside Europe in the interest of mutual prosperity.

The external borders thus serve those stakeholders with an interest in the ease of crossing borders legally as part of trade[25] and travel continuums, enabled by increased digitalisation of borders. The external borders further support implementation of the Union's policies for migration and asylum,[26] labour, free movement[27], customs[28], maritime affairs[29] and coast guard functions[30], internal security[31] and law enforcement[32] while contributing to the mitigation of risks to public health.[33] Embracing the whole-of-government approach, policies for e.g. neighbourhood, development cooperation and external action[34] can be leveraged off for the purpose of enhancing situational awareness as well as for achieving the necessary agreements to enable collaboration with and, where applicable, an operational presence in Third Countries, while working closely with them to also increase the effectiveness of returns.

25 Brussels, 18.2.2021 COM(2021) 66 final – Communication from the Commission to the European Parliament, the Council, the European Economic and Social Committee and the Committee of the Regions – Trade Policy Review — An Open, Sustainable and Assertive Trade Policy.
26 Brussels, 23.9.2020 COM(2020) 609 final – Communication from the Commission to the European Parliament, the Council, the European Economic and Social Committee and the Committee of the Regions on a New Pact on Migration and Asylum.
27 Brussels, 2.6.2021 COM(2021) 277 final — Communication from the Commission to the European Parliament and the Council — A strategy Towards a Fully Functioning and Resilient Schengen Area.
28 Regulation (EU) No 952/2013 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 9 October 2013 laying down the Union Customs Code (recast).
Customs reform: taking the Customs Union to the next level, Brussels 17 May 2023 COM (2023) 257 final.
29 Brussels, 24 June 2014 (OR. en) 11205/14 - European Union Maritime Security Strategy and its update Brussels, 10 March 2023 JOIN(2023) 8 final.
30 Brussels, 20.7.2021 C(2021) 5310 final Commission Recommendation of 20.7.2021 establishing a 'Practical Handbook' on European cooperation on coast guard functions.
31 Brussels, 24.7.2020 COM(2020) 605 final — Communication from the Commission to the European Parliament, the European Council, the Council, the European Economic and Social Committee and the Committee of the Regions on the EU Security Union.
32 Council of the EU doc no. 6481/21 dated 26 February 2021 — Council conclusions on the permanent continuation of the EU Policy Cycle for organised and serious international crime: EMPACT 2022 +
33 EU Healthy Gateways – Joint Action 04-2017 — Actions for preparedness at Points of Entry (ground crossings, airports, ports 24 October 2022.
34 Shared Vision, Common Action: A Stronger Europe: A Global Strategy for the European Union's Foreign And Security Policy, 2016.

Managing the external borders can further benefit from synergies with defence, crisis management and space, in particular in the context of capabilities and their development, where for example requirements converge for surveillance and communication capabilities as well as for systems that draw on technologies that enable e.g. remote piloting, artificial intelligence and augmented reality.

The European Border and Coast Guard has a unique opportunity and a responsibility to contribute to cross-cutting policies for aims such as sustainability,[35] by opting for energy efficient solutions which increase operational effectiveness, cut costs, and reduce hazardous emissions. As a big player on the market, aided by EU funding, it can also foster growth[36] in support of de-risking supply chains, especially in the context of sourcing of raw materials, components and energy outside Europe, as well as in relation to foreign direct investments[37] in Europe.

Ultimately, the concept of European Integrated Border Management is the shared responsibility of the whole European Border and Coast Guard – Frontex and the national authorities responsible for border management, including coast guards to the extent that they carry out maritime border control tasks, as well as the national authorities responsible for return. The implementation of European Integrated Border Management should also entail the opportunity to work with partners across organisational entities and policy areas, be it nationally, at a European level and with Third Countries and international organisations.

The implementation of the Technical and Operational European Integrated Border Management strategy is driven by foresight, preparedness, flexible and adaptable operational planning and response, enabled by continuous, close to real-time situation monitoring and situational awareness. This can only be achieved in close cooperation with other EU entities contributing to a coordinated, European system, as well as prioritisation of operational activities according to emerging threats and a changing environment, all while respecting fundamental rights.

35 Communication from the Commission to the European Parliament, The European Council, The Council, The European Economic and Social Committee and the Committee of the Regions — The European Green Deal, Brussels, 11 December 2019 COM (2019) 640 final.

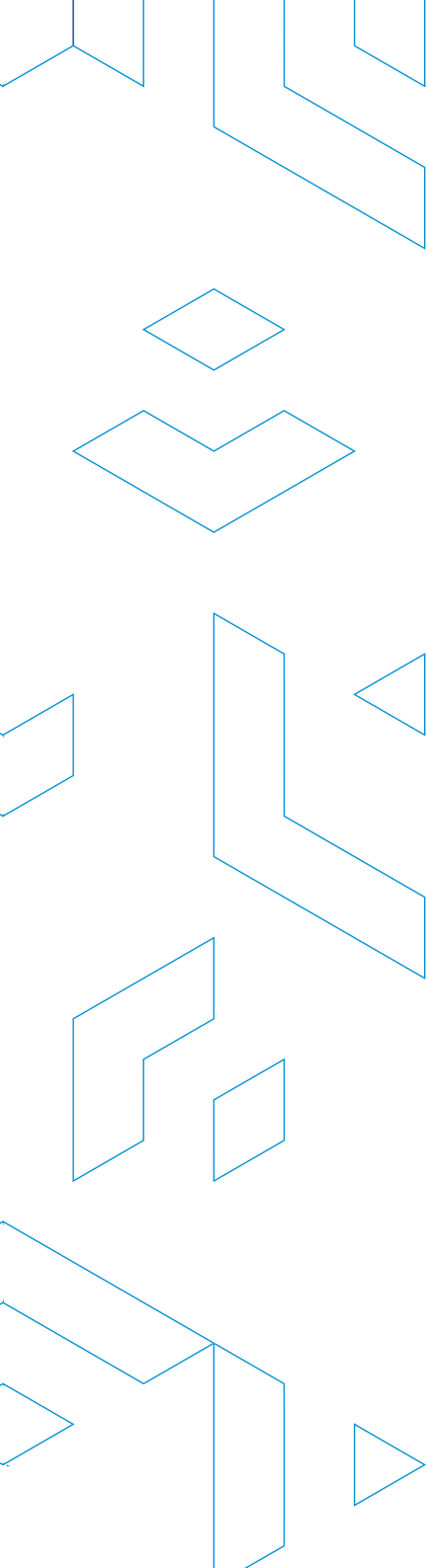
36 Brussels, 5.5.2021 COM(2021) 350 final – Communication from the Commission to the European Parliament, the Council, the European Economic and Social Committee and the Committee of the Regions – Updating the 2020 New Industrial Strategy: Building a stronger Single Market for Europe's recovery.

37 Regulation (EU) 2019/452 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 19 March 2019 establishing a framework for the screening of foreign direct investments into the Union.

To achieve effective migration management continuum, enhanced proactivity in return planning is needed. Overall efficiency and cost effectiveness must be ensured through Frontex operational support at all stages of border management and return. These actions require political support.

Finally, the European Maritime Security Strategy and the European Commission's Actions Plans e.g. on Central Mediterranean, Western Mediterranean and Pacific etc. are also interlinked with the present Strategy through various actions in the implementation plan.

All in all, European Integrated Border Management adds value in support of both European security and prosperity.





Strategy

3

3.1. Vision 2027 — A Strengthened European Border and Coast Guard Built on Trust to Protect and Connect Europe

The principles of shared responsibility and solidarity have underpinned what since 2016 has been defined as the European Border and Coast Guard. Times of crises have taught the European Border and Coast Guard that the whole is greater than the sum of its parts. Over the years, Member States and Frontex have learned to jointly tackle the recurring challenges faced at different parts of the external borders. As the journey towards fully integrating the responsibility for border management continues, the European Border and Coast Guard will be further cemented as **a community built on trust to protect and connect Europe, managing the borders at different stages of the border continuum and implementing returns in an integrated way,** while ensuring full compliance with International and European law, in full respect for fundamental rights.

Building on the Strategy of 2019, the ambition is for the European Border and Coast Guard to **become even more proactive** in the management of safe, secure and well-functioning external borders of the European area, where bona-fide travellers can cross the borders in an efficient manner. Working across all four tiers of the access control model, the aim is to be able to **predict, detect and prevent** challenging situations from reaching external borders. Should these challenges nonetheless occur, the European Border and Coast Guard should be prepared both in terms of awareness, capability and a solid, but flexible, chain of command to be able to **react, engage and stabilise** these situations in a timely manner.

Regular revision of operational priorities, foresight, further development of situational monitoring and operational analysis, including on the return data, as well as continuous reassessment of the surveillance and monitoring tools and capacity to trigger early warning, moving from analysis of past events towards prediction based on scenarios, allows to establish a proactive approach.

This should be **enabled by the operationally available capabilities,** including enhanced interoperability among various information systems, in the framework of a **solid governance structure.**

The Actions set out in the Implementation Plan, the Annex to this Strategy, are designed to implement respective steps of the Integrated Planning and Implementation Process. This will strengthen the proactive approach needed to reach the stated goals.

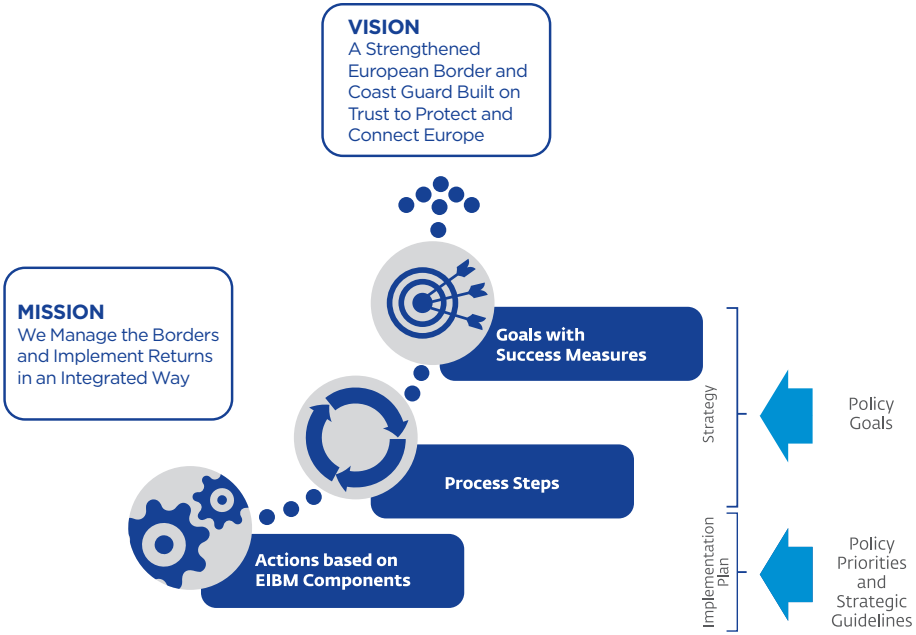


Figure 2: The structure of the Technical and Operational Strategy

3.2. Goals and Success Measures

This Strategy builds on the **Multiannual Strategic Policy goals**[38] for the European Integrated Border Management defined in the European Integrated Border Management Multiannual Strategic Policy. On top of six goals which stem directly from the Policy, two additional enabling goals have been added, covering the need for future-proofing the external borders,[39] sustainability, as well as good governance and compliance.[40]

For each of the goals, a high-level **success measure** has been identified to indicate progress in attaining a given goal, thus allowing the Strategy's implementation to be monitored. In this sense, the success measures are understood as qualitative or quantitative indicators. As the goals are relevant to the European Border and Coast Guard as a whole, both Frontex and Member States will contribute to their accomplishment. While there could be more success measures which support monitoring achievement of the goals, for each goal one has been chosen. Member States are free to select more in their national strategies if deemed more appropriate.

GOAL A:	Facilitate Legitimate Border Crossings
Success Measure:	Enhanced Identification of Travellers, Improved Data Management, Boosted Automation of Border Checks

Pre-entry checks of third-country nationals arriving to the EU and enhanced quality and efficiency of border check activities are essential for securing the external borders of the EU, improved management of legal migration to the EU, the reduction of overstays and the facilitation of entry through border crossing points, as well as ensuring the security of EU borders. Systematic use of existing large-scale EU information systems (the Schengen Information System, Visa Information System and the European Asylum Dactyloscopy Database, for example) and forthcoming new systems, such as the Entry Exit System and the European Travel Information Authorisation System is of paramount importance for improving the quality and efficiency of border management processes and procedures, as is the interoperability of such systems. Depending on their functionalities, these systems allow for better

38 1) Facilitate legitimate border crossings; 2) Ensure the effective prevention of unauthorised crossings of the external borders; 3) Increase the efficiency of the Union's return policy; 4) Detect and prevent serious crime with a cross-border dimension; 5) Achieve effective cooperation with Third Countries, International organisations and EU entities; 6) Ensure the swift registration and provision of care to persons in need of, or applying for, international protection.

39 7) Future-proof the external borders and accelerate innovation.

40 8) Ensure good governance and sound administration.

pre-screening of passengers and/or improved monitoring of border crossings. They help identify potential violations and facilitate the timely exchange of vital information among Member States. Furthermore, the full potential of the Passenger Name Record and Advance Passenger Information data should be used to improve risk assessments and facilitate the entry of bona fide travellers. The Passenger Name Record should be used to support law enforcement agencies in the prevention, detection, investigation and prosecution of terrorist offences and serious crime. The new and upgraded information systems and their interoperability will facilitate smooth and safe flows at border crossing points, leading not only to improved risk management, but also paving the way for enhancing automated border control processes, further harmonisation of border operating procedures and, as a result, increased overall effectiveness.

By effectively implementing and utilising Large-Scale EU Information Systems, along with the national databases, while streamlining border crossing procedures and ensuring high-level of **data quality,** the European Border and Coast Guard can work together to ensure proper prior control and appropriate identification. The pre-checks, together with improved quality of border checks, will contribute to a more secure and resilient Union.

Specific attention will be paid to the **systematic checks and compliance with the Schengen Borders Code,** if targeted checks must be used for the persons enjoying the right of free movement. At the same time, other parallel measures, such as sufficient staffing and adequate infrastructure, will contribute to facilitating smooth passenger flows.

GOAL B:	Ensure the Effective Prevention of Unauthorised Crossings of the External Borders
Success Measure:	Reduced Unauthorised Border-Crossings and Secondary Movements

Effectively preventing and addressing the challenges of unauthorised crossings of the external borders requires **implementation of intelligence-driven risk-based measures**, on the basis of near-real time operational data related to the impact levels attributed to the external border sections. These could encompass the application of advanced surveillance and monitoring capabilities, including at the pre-frontier areas, which draw on integrated sensor networks based on land, sea, air and space-based platforms, from which data is fused and processed, aided by e.g. artificial intelligence to enable more effective detection, identification and tracking of unauthorised crossings. Advanced technologies must observe the right to respect

for privacy and be subject to appropriate and fundamental rights and data protection impact assessments. In addition, risk analysis and vulnerability assessment should contribute to guiding the deployment of the necessary capabilities at key external border sections, ensuring adequate coverage of the most critical areas.

Furthermore, fostering cross-border cooperation and **information-sharing** between the European Border and Coast Guard, other EU bodies and Institutions, neighbouring countries, and regional and international organisations will improve situational awareness and enhance the ability to predict, detect and prevent potential unauthorised crossings. By integrating these measures and initiatives, subject to a favourable fundamental rights assessment, the overall detection and reduction of unauthorised crossings can be significantly improved.

GOAL C:	Increase the Efficiency of the Union's Return Policy
Success Measure:	**Increased Returns**

The successful implementation of the Union's Return policy requires a **whole-of-government approach** across the EU. The European Border and Coast Guard has a role to play in its implementation, in full coherence with the policy priorities of the Union and through all phases of the return cycle. In all return phases, it is essential to ensure that cooperation within the European Border and Coast Guard community is well-functioning. The same applies to cooperation with other national and European stakeholders, international organisations and Third Countries, not least drawing on the return liaison officers. During the pre-return stage, return and reintegration counselling for both forced and assisted voluntary return it is critical to **facilitate the overall return process**, ensure the monitoring of returns and – where applicable – promote options for voluntary return. Return and reintegration counselling should become a core component of return case management. When implementing voluntary and non-voluntary return, the European Border and Coast Guard should, whenever deemed appropriate, make use of the options offered by Frontex to also achieve economies of scale and reduce environmental footprint. Additionally, enhanced cooperation within the European Border and Coast Guard community is needed to enable systematic monitoring of return flights applied as a standard activity.

Furthermore, in the post-return phase, the European Border and Coast Guard has a role to play in providing technical and operational support in reintegration assistance, which can be significantly facilitated through development of cooperation and capacity building projects. All these efforts can be made more effective by linking them with the timely exchange of data and information on return: therefore, systematic use of the renewed Schengen Information System functionality concerning return alerts, further **digitalisation of the national return systems** and further development of the common data sharing platform based on the Frontex Return Case Management System model are all essential. In addition, it is of paramount importance that return needs analysis and tailored situational awareness abilities are developed, to foster the whole-of-government approach and enable operational actors to prioritise, develop their capabilities and make the most of their resources. Together, these measures can help increase non-voluntary and voluntary returns from the EU to Third Countries.

GOAL D:	Detect and Prevent Serious Crime with a Cross-Border Dimension
Success Measure:	Improved Capability for Intelligence-Led Risk-Based Operational Actions Countering Cross Border Crime and Terrorism

Border surveillance and interception capabilities are essential to be able to detect and prevent cross-border crime. So is the need to strengthen **information sharing and analytical capabilities**, working closely with partners within and outside the EU, to produce actionable intelligence, including establishing new partnerships for this purpose. The illegal activities may be related to e.g. crime associated with migrant smuggling and trafficking in e.g. human beings, wildlife, drugs, contraband, vehicles, firearms and ammunitions, wildlife, art and waste. Whether it is cross-border crime or terrorism, there are organised networks with established supply chains, of which each link has its own profit margin. The profit is used not only to reward the people involved, but also for investments in the enterprise, including in highly sophisticated technological capabilities. Increasing the success rate of risk-based actions aimed at preventing activities with a criminal intent from crossing the borders applied in accordance with the European Border and Coast Guard priorities should help reduce the profitability of such activites and, ultimately, the networks' abilities to reward and further invest.

GOAL E:	Achieve Effective Cooperation with Third Countries
Success Measure:	Increased Information Exchange and Joint Operational Intelligence-Led Risk-Based Activities Carried out with Third Countries

Effective cooperation with Third Countries is vital to achieve the aims of the Strategy. Subject to a prior fundamental rights impact assessment, a good measure of effective cooperation is the **ability to share information,** in particular intelligence, and to act together operationally. The higher the quality of intelligence gathered from Third Countries of origin and transit, the easier it is for the European Border and Coast Guard to take preventive action.

Concerted EU actions comprising common EU negotiation power, capacity building with an emphasis on strengthening the capacity of Third Countries to manage their own borders and operational activities in Third Countries, including with executive powers based on EU status agreements, all support third-country integrated border management capacities whilst promoting EU standards and principles, including a rights-based approach to migration management and reduce pressure on the EU's external borders. The priority for capacity building is set to adjacent Third Countries, as defined by the risk analysis, i.e. the Mediterranean, and by the enlargement policy priorities, i.e. East Europe and the Western Balkans.

GOAL F:	Ensure the Swift Registration and Provision of Care to Persons in Need of, or Applying for, International Protection
Success Measure:	Enhanced Systematic Level of Registration and Processing

The EU has a **legal and moral obligation to protect individuals fleeing persecution, conflict, or any other forms of human rights abuses.** Swift registration and provision of care help fulfil these obligations, ensuring that vulnerable individuals receive the necessary support and assistance they require. Registering and providing care to vulnerable people and to those potentially in need of international protection is crucial for upholding human rights standards which cannot be compromised, starting with guaranteeing every individual's right to claim asylum in accordance with the EU and international law. However, aided by the rollout of the large-scale information systems and coupled with enhanced processes and procedures implemented by adequate numbers of competent, properly trained and relevant staff, registration can be performed more effectively, thereby allowing vulnerable persons to be identified, referred to appropriate procedures and have their special needs addressed faster. Swift registration also contributes

to a more efficient asylum system, as when promptly identifying and documenting individuals seeking international protection, the authorities can process their applications in a timely manner.

Additionally, **enhancing the level of registration and processing** of migrants at the EU external borders, especially by ensuring comprehensive checks and systematic registration in relevant databases, in particular the European Asylum Dactyloscopy Database, has a positive impact on internal security by helping the authorities to identify security threats, deterring illegal activities and reducing the likelihood of secondary movements within the EU. It is also instrumental for effective implementation of return policy, as it contributes to a swift return process.

GOAL G:	Future-Proof the External Borders and Accelerate Innovation
Success Measure:	Improved Availability of Relevant, Resilient and Sustainable Capabilities

To future-proof the borders, there is a need to be able to **anticipate what opportunities and threats lie ahead, as well as to acknowledge current strengths and weaknesses** of the European Border and Coast Guard in relation to both conventional challenges associated with migration, crime, terrorism and public health as well as novel hybrid and cyber threats. This will support continuous improvement, so that our border and coast guard capabilities meet both the operational and administrative needs of today and can adapt to those of tomorrow. The ambition is to **increase the overall availability of capabilities** by streamlining processes, reducing lead and down time and avoiding single sourcing, especially in supply chains from outside Europe. To stay at the forefront, it is essential to develop a research and innovation cooperation community, also coordinated with the work of other relevant fora, supporting the implementation of the European Border and Coast Guard research agenda and to monitor and to explore research and innovation solutions in support of the European Border and Coast Guard's organisational and operational needs. Also, it is crucial for the capability development processes to allow for managing intellectual property effectively and to enable smooth uptake of relevant innovation, drawing on EU and nationally funded research, and exploring public private partnerships. Furthermore, it is important to acknowledge the anticipated evolution of the concept of borders beyond the physical realm, considering the stakes of both state and non-state actors in virtual and cognitive realms as well as in space. At the core of future-proofing the borders and accelerated innovation is the **staff of the European Border and Coast Guard** – their education, training and careers, underpinned by a robust competency management framework.

Finally, one of the core enablers for sustaining the European Border and Coast Guard's ability to manage borders and returns is **embracing the principles of sustainability**, especially across the capability development and management activities. This helps to increase operational effectiveness through e.g. supporting sustainable and resilient equipment and other capabilities, creating opportunities for budget savings through efficient resource management, mainly related to energy efficiency and optimised energy consumption. At the same time, it is a way for the European Border and Coast Guard community to support the overarching strategic priorities of the EU such as the European Green Deal and digital transformation, and contribute to, among others, increasing energy efficiency, reducing the negative environmental impact and helping to mitigate the climate-driven crisis, which is one of the factors driving both regular and irregular migration.

GOAL H:	Ensure Good Governance and Sound Administration
Success Measure:	Strengthened Governance and Compliance

The successful implementation of this Strategy relies on **strengthened governance of the whole European Border and Coast Guard**, sharing the same European values. Solid governance relies on respect for the principles of the rule of law, in full compliance with EU and international legislation, including the Charter of Fundamental Rights of the European Union. Effective fundamental rights monitoring of a range of border management activities can make an important contribution to enhancing the transparency and accountability surrounding activity at the EU external border.

The priority is to establish **integrated planning systems** for capabilities, operations and contingencies for the whole European Border and Coast Guard, including the Standing Corps. Establishing governance at a European and national level enables implementation of European Integrated Border Management.

The implementation of **efficient quality control** at the European and national levels is also part of effective governance of EU borders. Schengen evaluations, vulnerability assessment and national quality control help identify weaknesses in national border mechanisms, flag urgent issues and allow for timely action in relation to prioritised areas.

3.3. The Process of Achieving the Goals

3.3.1. The Integrated Process for Planning and Implementation

The process of achieving the goals defined in this Strategy, serving as the vehicle for implementing European Integrated Border Management, builds on the concept of Integrated Planning as described in Article 9 of the Regulation. It not only covers planning of operations, contingencies and capability development, but also the subsequent implementation of the plans. Furthermore, it is complemented by governance elements pertaining to each phase.

With an ambition to continuously improve, the Integrated Planning and Implementation Process is set out in four phases, the first of which addresses planning based on the understanding of the current situation and anticipated evolution. Once established, the plans are implemented through a series of actions. The results are subsequently evaluated against what had been set out in the plans. The conclusions from the evaluation provide a basis to learn from and to identify areas for improvement, which feeds the next process cycle. Given that European Integrated Border Management is a shared responsibility between Member States and the Agency, with a scope stretching beyond the remit of the European Border and Coast Guard, there is a need to govern the process cycle to ensure that timely decisions are taken throughout the process.

The Integrated Planning and Implementation Process cycle cements the continuous and iterative nature of European Integrated Border Management, with each phase informing and influencing the others. Core elements of the Regulation can be found in each phase and the process mapping allows for better understanding of the inter-dependencies. Consequently, these core elements have been reflected as process steps. Overall, the Integrated Planning and Implementation Process-driven approach ensures that European Integrated Border Management continues to be adaptive to change, to effectively serve both border management and return. It further allows for the improved harnessing of synergies in the interest of a whole-of-government approach.

3.3.2. Process Steps

The Integrated Planning and Implementation Process cycle identifies the following process steps: **Planning**, **Implementation**, **Evaluation**, **Improvement** which are connected by **Governance**.

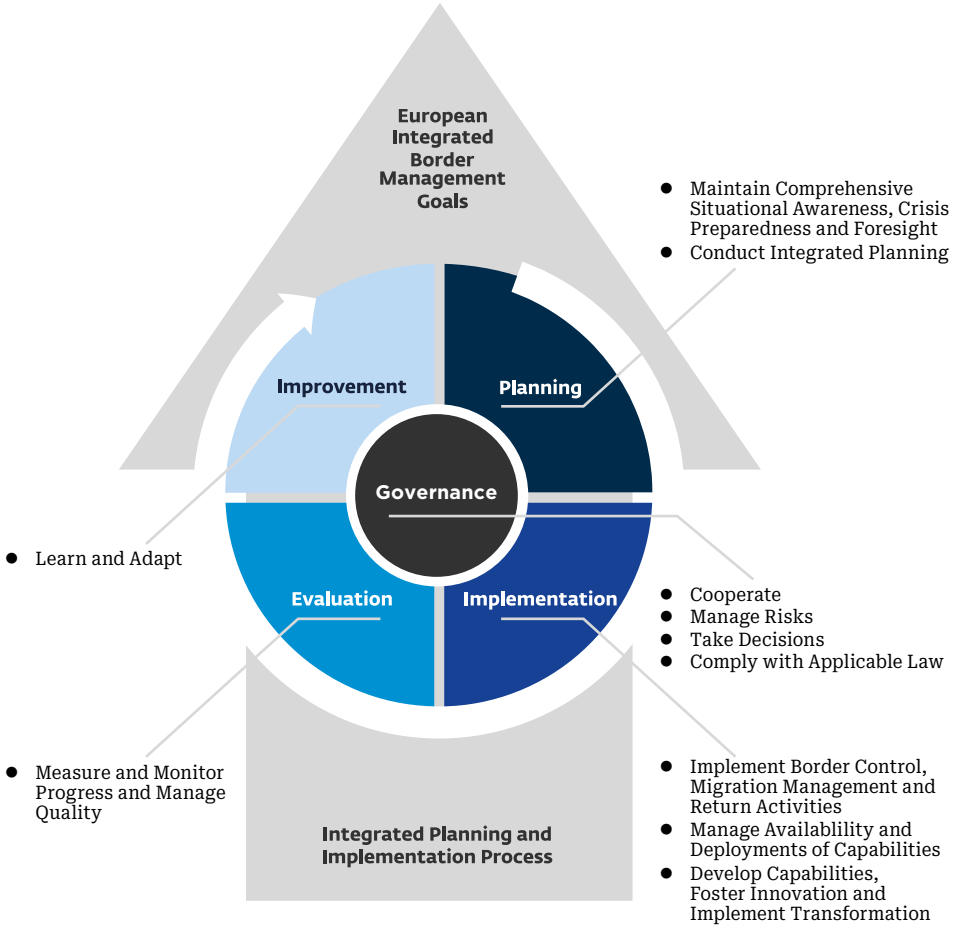


Figure 3: The Integrated Planning and Implementation Process

PLANNING

Maintain Comprehensive Situational Awareness, Crisis Preparedness and Foresight

Working closely with partners to gather high-quality information feeds the analysis of risks and vulnerabilities, as well as forecasting, including on return. This, combined with real-time surveillance across the external borders and in the pre-frontier area, is key to ensuring abilities in comprehensive situation monitoring and in predicting the evolution of scenarios in the immediate, short-, medium- and long- term, as well as in producing early warnings. This supports informed decision-making, based on the intelligence produced.

The EU capacity for more common and analytical migration situational awareness, early warning, forecasting, and contingency planning needs strengthening, including via automation of data gathering, analysis and information exchange. This requires the European Border and Coast Guard to work even closer with relevant actors in the interfaces of the other policy areas. Frontex has a pivotal role in enabling a European situational picture, to ensure better decision-making at the European level.

Conduct Integrated Planning

Managing current risks and opportunities continually, as well as regular revision of operational priorities, allows for a more proactive approach concerning planning the operational course of action and contingencies, for both border management and return-related activities. This further supports the process of planning the availability and deployments of capabilities, enabling the necessary level of responsiveness and helping adapt to change.

The strategic risk and opportunities management informs the necessary investments to be prepared for anticipated future capability needs. In this sense, capability development planning should address the full scope of capabilities, both operational, administrative and those that are underpinning in the form of concepts and standards that foster harmonisation, interoperability and process streamlining. Furthermore, the Integrated Planning needs to encompass strategies and plans for cooperation, as well as internal development plans and the programming of the respective national authorities in Member States and Frontex.

IMPLEMENTATION

Implement Border Control, Migration Management and Return Activities

Ensuring a response to ongoing and emerging challenges by executing the planned course of action upstream, adapting as and when needed, should ideally prevent the occurrence of events that have a negative impact upon the EU. However, should such events nonetheless materialise, remaining vigilant allows for timely reaction and situation stabilisation. A solid management structure, such as a well-established chain of command, enables the implementation of the operational activities in a flexible manner, enabling prioritisation and adaptation to different operational theatres.

Where hostile state actors instrumentalise migration, there is an increased need to review the operational response and deployment modalities to differentiate from traditional migration flows, and to address growing exposure of Frontex, Member States and third-country personnel to violence and security threats.

Downstream, the effective implementation of return-related activities will shorten lead times across all phases of the process, which is in the interests of both those affected and the authorities and agencies involved. Moreover, this will further contribute to preventing future events at the external borders that otherwise could lead to the need for return activities to be implemented.

Manage Availability and Deployments of Capabilities

Key to the effectiveness of the implementation of border management and return-related activities is the ability to generate the availability of the necessary capabilities as planned, allocate them to the operational activities and subsequently manage their deployments to operational areas, while catering to redeployments and reinforcement needs. One of the elements of these processes is the need to ensure gender-balanced deployments.

Develop Capabilities, Foster Innovation and Implement Transformation

Transformative actions to meet future needs require initiatives across all capability lines of development – e.g. doctrine, policies and concepts, personnel, education and training, science and technology, equipment, systems and services, logistics, facilities and infrastructure, safety, security and health, standardisation and interoperability.

Combined with systematic promotion of innovation, beyond what is driven by technology, these actions allow for the effective transformation of operational concepts, to be able to deliver the appropriate modular and scalable effects to tackle the anticipated challenges.

EVALUATION

Measure and Monitor Progress and Manage Quality

Continuous improvement is enabled by measuring and monitoring the progress and effectiveness of implementation processes against the objectives, as well as by scrutinising adherence to legal requirements.

To be able to comprehensively evaluate the effectiveness of the established plans and their implementation, there is a need for complementarity and synchronicity of the quality management at the European and national levels. The scope thus includes e.g. European and national quality control mechanisms, the evaluation processes of operational activities coordinated by Frontex and internationally established standards for the assurance of quality in organisations. Moreover, the findings should be compatible in format, scope and timeliness of remedial action. These will steer the funding priorities of EU funding instruments.

IMPROVEMENT

Learn and Adapt

Findings from the evaluation phase can only be put to good use if the process of learning is institutionalised and leads to actions that enable adaptation in the interest of continuous improvement.

GOVERNANCE

Cooperate, Manage Risks, Take Decisions and Comply with Applicable Law

Given the complexity of European Integrated Border Management and its implementation, which involves numerous policy areas and inherent multiple authorities and agencies, the European Border and Coast Guard being at its core, it is crucial to maintain a robust system for coherent and inclusive governance throughout the whole Integrated Planning and Implementation process. Such a system needs to ensure and maintain high-levels of situational awareness of adequate granularity, enabling proper risk management and the taking of informed decisions. In addition, it should be designed and implemented in a way that it can act as a robust safeguard for respect for applicable law in all aspects of European Integrated Border Management. This includes full compliance with EU and international law, including respect for fundamental rights in all activities undertaken under the European Integrated Border Management umbrella. Cross-sectoral cooperation, including with national bodies in charge of protecting fundamental rights, such as National Human Rights Institutions, Ombudsman institutions, National Preventive Mechanisms means that available expertise can be benefited from in full.

Furthermore, with an integrated governance system it will be possible to plan and consolidate the contribution of the European Border and Coast Guard and the wider community of European Integrated Border Management to the strategic goals of the EU. This includes areas such as the EU's Strategic Autonomy and its ability to work with partners, the strengthening of the technological and industrial base, increased digitalisation at the borders and elsewhere, all in the interests of growth, pushing the boundaries in increasing energy efficiency and reducing the environmental footprint. Key to all of this is the essence of European Integrated Border Management as enshrined in the Regulation — cooperation among Member States, between Member States and the Agency and with Third Countries — and, more importantly, with actors and stakeholders in all relevant policy areas.

3.3.3. Actions

The Implementation Plan, which is an Annex to the Strategy, is structured around the European Integrated Border Management components, designed to attain the expected output of the respective process steps to achieve the goals as set out in this Strategy. The actions consequently address both the national and European level, bearing in mind that Member States will have flexibility in the subsequent specification and implementation of the actions of their respective action plans. For each action, the timeframe, milestones, necessary resources and monitoring arrangements are defined in accordance with the Policy requirements.

3.3.4. Interlinkages between Goals, Process Steps and Actions

Identifying the relationship between the individual actions listed in the Implementation Plan under each of the European Integrated Border Management components and the relevant elements of the Integrated Process for Planning and Implementation makes it possible to, consequently, also follow the connections between the European Integrated Border Management components and the goals defined in this Strategy. At the same time, it needs to be highlighted that a single action may connect to several steps of the process and, subsequently, contribute to more than one goal. As a rule, all European Integrated Border Management components, through their actions, together help reaching the goals.

The table below illustrates how each goal is linked with the process steps.

		PROCESS STEPS							
		Planning		Implementation			Evaluation	Improvement	Governance
		1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
		Maintain Comprehensive Situational Awareness, Crisis Preparedness and Foresight	Conduct Integrated Planning	Implement Border Control, Migration Management and Return Activities	Manage Availability and Deployments of Capabilities	Develop Capabilities, Foster Innovation and Implement Transformation	Measure and Monitor Progress and Manage Quality	Learn and Adapt	Cooperate, Manage Risks, Take Decisions and Comply with Applicable Law
GOALS A	Facilitate Legitimate Border Crossings	•	•	•	•	•	•	•	•
B	Ensure the Effective Prevention of Unauthorised Crossings of the External Borders	•	•	•	•	•	•	•	•
C	Increase the Efficiency of the Union's Return Policy	•	•	•	•	•	•	•	•
D	Detect and Prevent Serious Crime with a Cross-Border Dimension	•	•	•	•	•	•	•	•
E	Achieve Effective Cooperation with Third Countries	•	•	•		•	•	•	•
F	Ensure the Swift Registration and Provision of Care to Persons in Need of, or Applying for, International Protection		•	•		•	•	•	•
G	Future-Proof the External Borders and Accelerate Innovation		•	•		•	•	•	•
H	Ensure Good Governance and Sound Administration		•	•	•	•	•	•	•

Table 1: Strategy goals mapped against the steps of the Integrated Panning and Implementation Process.

The second table shows how the European Integrated Border Management components feature across the process steps.

		PROCESS STEPS							
		Planning		Implementation			Evaluation	Improvement	Governance
		1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
		Maintain Comprehensive Situational Awareness, Crisis Preparedness and Foresight	Conduct Integrated Planning	Implement Border Control, Migration Management and Return Activities	Manage Availability and Deployments of Capabilities	Develop Capabilities, Foster Innovation and Implement Transformation	Measure and Monitor Progress and Manage Quality	Learn and Adapt	Cooperate, Manage Risks, Take Decisions and Comply with Applicable Law
COMPONENTS									
1	Border Control	•		•	•			•	
2	Search and Rescue		•	•				•	
3	Risk Analysis	•	•					•	•
4	Information Exchange	•		•			•	•	•
5	Inter-Agency Cooperation	•		•			•	•	•
6	Cooperation at European Level	•		•			•	•	•
7	Cooperation with Third Countries	•	•	•			•	•	•
8	Measures within th Area of Free Movement		•	•				•	
9	Returns		•	•				•	
10	Large Scale Information Systems	•	•	•		•		•	
11	Quality Control	•	•			•	•	•	•
12	Union Funding	•	•	•		•		•	
13	Fundamental Rights		•	•		•	•	•	•
14	Education and Training		•			•	•	•	
15	Research and Innovation		•			•		•	

Table 2: EIBM components mapped against the steps of the Integrated Planning and Implementation Process.


FRONTEX
EUROPEAN BORDER AND COAST GUARD

Implementation of the Strategy

4

4.1. European Level

To ensure the implementation of the Strategy and the achievement of its goals, **Frontex will transpose the goals and component-based actions in this Strategy into its relevant sub-strategies, plans and programming documents**, ensuring full alignment. These include: the Multiannual Programming and Annual Work Programmes[41], the Capability Development Plan and inherent lines of development addressing e.g. doctrine, policies and concepts, personnel, education and training, science and technology, equipment, systems and services, logistics, facilities and infrastructure, safety, security and health, standardisation and interoperability. It further includes the established International Cooperation Strategy and the Information and Communication Technology Strategy.

4.2. National Level

In accordance with the Multiannual Strategic Policy Cycle, as per Article 8(6) of the Regulation, in order to implement the Multiannual Strategic Policy for European Integrated Border Management, **following the adoption of the technical and operational strategy for European Integrated Border Management, the Member States shall establish national strategies for European Integrated Border Management.**[42] This should be done through close cooperation between all national authorities responsible for the management of external borders and return. Those national strategies must be in line with Articles 1 and 3 of the Regulation, the Multiannual Strategic Policy for European and the technical and operational strategy.

The Multiannual Strategic Policy, in Annex II of the European Integrated Border Management Communication, outlines the following requirements for national strategies for European Integrated Border Management:

- There should be **one national strategy** for each Member State.
- It should establish **a centralised governance structure** for European Integrated Border Management that coordinates all relevant authorities involved in border management and return, and that takes into account the implications of other EU policies implemented at the external borders of the Member State by the competent national authorities within their respective mandates, such as police, customs and sanitary control authorities.

41 As per Art. 102 of the European Border and Coast Guard Regulation.
42 As per Art. 8(6) of the European Border and Coast Guard Regulation.

- It must be developed **in line with the political strategy decided by the EU institutions, the technical and operational strategy of the Agency and with the requirements of the Schengen *acquis*.**
- It shall **build on the findings and recommendations issued in the Thematic Schengen 2019-2020 Evaluation** of the national European Integrated Border Management strategies.
- It should be **based on the fifteen components** as stipulated in Article 3 of the Regulation, but may also cover areas of national competence, if this is considered appropriate.
- It should set out **national border management coordination structures** and participation by the Member State in relevant EU mechanisms coordinated by Frontex and other relevant EU actors.
- It should clearly establish the current and planned **allocation of human and financial resources**, and the main stages for the development of the necessary infrastructure.
- It should establish a **review and monitoring mechanism.**
- It should have **multiannual coverage**, ideally taking into account the programming cycle of the multiannual financial framework.
- It should be **accompanied by an action plan** outlining the key measures, the timeframe, the milestones, the necessary resources and the monitoring arrangements.

In addition, considering the uncertainties related to the multiannual feature of such action plans, Member States may also outline possible estimated risks to the implementation of any identified action. They may also consider establishing a mechanism to conduct a regular review of the action plans.

It should be highlighted that, as long as the requirements above are respected, the Member States have flexibility as to the structure and format of their own strategies and accompanying action plans. This also relates to the inclusion of additional elements which the Members States may deem necessary.

The Technical and Operational Strategy for European Integrated Border Management adds two additional goals in relation to those provided by the Multiannual Strategic Policy. Member States, depending on their national situational and, in particular, their geographical locations, may need to focus more on certain goals of this Strategy when creating their national strategies. The same applies to the fifteen components of European Integrated Border Management, which should be addressed in the national strategies. As for the actions listed in the Annex to the Strategy, the Implementation Plan, Member States should, as a minimum, refer to and further define those actions for which this Implementation Plan indicates national responsibility.

To facilitate the implementation of the Strategy at both the European and national level, and with a view to assist Member States with the drafting of the national strategies for European Integrated Border Management, Frontex will support the development of a handbook, accompanying the Strategy and addressing in detail relevant practical aspects of the implementation of the European Integrated Border Management.

Besides the national financial resources, Member States will be able to facilitate the implementation of their newly established national strategies for European Integrated Border Management from and in line with their respective national Border Management and Visa Instrument (BMVI) programme. Eligible actions can also be funded by other EU funding instruments.

4.3. Monitoring

The Frontex Management Board will be updated on a regular basis on the progress of the Strategy's implementation. The Frontex Management Board Working Group on European Integrated Border Management will support the Management Board in accordance with its main objectives and areas of responsibility.[43] This includes providing advice and proposing possible updates to the Implementation Plan, defined in the Annex to the Strategy, to the Management Board.

The monitoring will be informed by input from the information and data collection and processing, as well as by reporting frameworks and mechanisms, managed in accordance with relevant legal provisions, including:

- The annual activity report of Frontex submitted to the Management Board.[44] This offers a national situational picture of the European Border Surveillance System.
- Information and data exchange between Frontex and the national authorities responsible for border management and return as per Article 100 (2e) of the Regulation.
- The quality control mechanisms of European Integrated Border Management, including Vulnerability Assessment, the Schengen Evaluation Mechanism and national mechanisms.
- Information exchange through the European Integrated Border Management Working Group as well as relevant fora and networks such as the Pooled Resources Network, the Capability Development Network and the Risk Analysis Network alongside engaging with liaison officers.
- Results and evaluation of operational and return activities.

The monitoring mechanism will allow assessment of the need for adaptation of the implementation plan, should global circumstances and the operational environment change.

The national strategies for European Integrated Border Management will be evaluated by the Schengen Evaluation and Monitoring Mechanism.

43 As per Frontex MB Decision 33/202, Art.2.

44 CAAR – Consolidated Annual Activity Report.



5 Evaluation

The European Commission will evaluate the Multiannual Strategic Policy Cycle for European Integrated Border Management and will provide guidance in terms of updating the technical and operational strategy.

ANNEX

Technical and Operational Strategy for European Integrated Border Management 2023–2027

Implementation Plan

The Implementation Plan which is subject to annual review is not part of this publication and is available for download via the QR code provided below

or the following **LINK**.

FRONTEX

EUROPEAN BORDER AND COAST GUARD AGENCY

Plac Europejski 6 • 00-844 Warsaw • Poland
frontex@frontex.europa.eu • www.frontex.europa.eu
© European Border and Coast Guard Agency (Frontex), 2025
All rights reserved. Reproduction is authorised provided the source is acknowledged. FPI-25.0113
Luxembourg: Publications Office of the European Union, 2025

PDF WEB	ISBN 978-92-9411-175-3	DOI 10.2819/5142818	TT-01-25-017-EN-N
PDF X	ISBN 978-92-9411-176-0	DOI 10.2819/7910174	TT-01-25-017-EN-C

Publications Office of the European Union